

Artists in Lebanon Keep Creating During Conflict

Charbel Samuel Aoun is a working artist in the Middle Eastern nation of Lebanon. As the Israeli military launches a deadly attack against the militant group Hezbollah in his home country, Aoun asks, "Does art still have a place in such a crisis?"

Lebanon has long played an important part in the Arab world's artistic community. It has been a center for arts, music and theater, combining traditional and modern influences.

Now, Lebanese artists are using their work as a way to express the anger and loss they feel after a year-long Israeli offensive that has killed more than 3,200 people, most of them since September.

Aoun's works of art are directly connected to the conflicts Lebanon has seen. In 2013, he began gathering dust from Syrian refugee camps in Lebanon to create a series of paintings before moving on to explore other materials.

Lebanese artist Charbel Samuel Aoun works on an art piece using dust mixed with resin in Fanar, Lebanon on November 8, 2024. (REUTERS/Yara Nardi)

Now, he says the darkness and hopelessness of the war and the waste left behind by Israel's intense bombing campaign have renewed his desire to create art from dust.

"You either stop everything or keep going with the little that still has meaning," he said.

Two of his exhibitions have been canceled due to the war. While he once made money from selling art, he now also relies on selling honey from his beehives, which he first set up as a project to create art from beeswax.

"I can no longer rely on the art market," he said.

No demand for art

Exhibition spaces across Beirut have closed in recent months. Their owners told Reuters there is no demand to buy art at this time. Even Lebanon's famous Sursock Museum has stored its collections underground.

Lebanese singer and musician Joy Fayad holds her guitar in her studio in Mazraat Yachouh, Lebanon November 6, 2024. (REUTERS/Yara Nardi)

Lebanese singer and musician Joy Fayad has also struggled with the emotional cost of the conflict. It has made it difficult for her to perform for months.

"It limited my creativity; it was like I shut down. I couldn't give to others, nor to myself," Fayad, 36, said.

Instead, she threw her energy into songwriting. One line in a new song reads: "You are from the downtrodden people, whose word has been silenced, and by their weapons, you are paying the price with your blood."

She recently began performing again, singing for displaced and refugee children in Lebanon at an event north of Beirut.

"They're changing the atmosphere, having fun after such a difficult period," she said, especially for those who became used to the sound of bombs instead of music.

I'm Andrew Smith.

Emilie Madi and Riham Alkousaa reported this story for Reuters. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

exhibition - n. นิทรรศการ: เหตุการณ์ที่มีการนำวัตถุ (เช่น งานศิลปะ) มาจัดแสดงในพื้นที่สาธารณะให้ผู้คนดู หรือการแสดงต่อสาธารณะของบางสิ่ง

beehive - n. รังผึ้ง: รังที่ผึ้งสร้างขึ้นเพื่ออยู่อาศัย

beeswax - n. ขี้ผึ้ง: ขี้ผึ้งที่ผลิตโดยผึ้งซึ่งนำมาใช้ทำเทียนและผลิตภัณฑ์อื่นๆ

shut down - phrasal verb. (ไม่เป็นทางการ) หยุดทำงาน: ทำให้ (คู่ต่อสู้) ไม่ประสบความสำเร็จ ไม่สามารถทำคะแนน หรือไม่สามารถทำงานได้

downtrodden - adj. ถูกกดขี่: ไร้ความหวังเนื่องจากถูกปฏิบัติอย่างเลวร้ายโดยผู้มีอำนาจ รัฐบาล หรือผู้ที่คล้ายกัน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. Who is Charbel Samuel Aoun, and what is his immediate concern according to the article?

- A. A Lebanese politician worried about the economy during the conflict.
- B. An Israeli military leader concerned about cultural preservation.
- C. An artist in Lebanon questioning the relevance of art during a crisis.
- D. A Hezbollah militant discussing the history of art in the region.

2. What has been Lebanon's historical significance in the Arab world's artistic community?

- A. It was known as a minor contributor, focusing only on traditional crafts.
- B. It served primarily as a commercial hub with little artistic output.

C. It has been a major center for arts, music, and theater, blending traditional and modern influences.

D. It was a center for modern art only, rejecting traditional forms completely.

3. What is the primary motivation for Lebanese artists creating art currently?

A. To attract tourists and boost the local economy.

B. To document historical events for future generations.

C. To express their feelings of anger and loss due to the ongoing conflict.

D. To promote peace and reconciliation among the warring factions.

4. What unique material did Charbel Samuel Aoun use for his art in 2013?

A. Recycled plastics from urban areas.

B. Metal fragments from conflict zones.

C. Dust gathered from Syrian refugee camps.

D. Natural dyes extracted from Lebanese plants.

5. According to the article's accompanying photo caption, what materials is Charbel Samuel Aoun currently using for his artwork?

A. Oil paints and traditional canvases.

B. Dust mixed with resin.

C. Watercolors and paper.

D. Clay and sculpting tools.

6. What has recently reignited Charbel Samuel Aoun's desire to create art from dust?

A. A new commission from an international gallery.

B. The hope for an end to the conflict and a return to peace.

C. The darkness, hopelessness of the war, and waste from bombing campaigns.

D. A renewed interest in the historical significance of the material.

7. What does Charbel Samuel Aoun believe artists should do during the current crisis?

A. Completely cease all artistic activities until the conflict ends.

B. Continue to create with the few things that still hold meaning.

C. Focus exclusively on commercial art to support themselves.

D. Migrate to other countries where art is more appreciated.

8. How has the conflict specifically affected Charbel Samuel Aoun's art career and financial stability?

A. He has received more funding for his art projects.

- B. Two of his exhibitions were canceled, and he now sells honey for income.
- C. He shifted his focus entirely to selling beeswax art for profit.
- D. He started teaching art workshops to supplement his income.

9. What is Charbel Samuel Aoun's current assessment of the art market?

- A. It is booming, offering artists many opportunities.
- B. It is stable but challenging for emerging artists.
- C. He can no longer depend on it for financial support.
- D. It has transitioned successfully to online platforms.

10. What evidence supports the claim that there is 'no demand for art' in Beirut?

- A. Art prices have drastically dropped, making art affordable for everyone.
- B. Numerous new galleries have opened, but attendance is low.
- C. Exhibition spaces have closed, and the Sursock Museum's collections are stored underground.
- D. Artists are choosing to leave Beirut for other cultural centers.

11. How has the conflict emotionally impacted Lebanese singer and musician Joy Fayad?

- A. It has motivated her to create more uplifting music.
- B. It caused emotional struggle, making it difficult for her to perform for months.
- C. She used the conflict as inspiration to tour internationally.
- D. It led her to explore different genres of music for the first time.

12. How did the conflict affect Joy Fayad's creativity, according to her own words?

- A. It opened up new avenues for artistic expression.
- B. She felt it 'limited my creativity; it was like I shut down.'
- C. She found it easier to write for others than for herself.
- D. Her creativity flourished due to the intense emotions.

13. What artistic avenue did Joy Fayad pursue when her performance ability was hindered, and what theme is reflected in her new song?

- A. She focused on instrumental composition, reflecting themes of peace and reconciliation.
- B. She turned to songwriting, with a theme about the suffering and silenced voices of oppressed people.
- C. She began painting, illustrating the resilience of the Lebanese landscape.
- D. She started teaching music lessons, emphasizing national pride and unity.

14. For whom has Joy Fayad recently resumed performing?

- A. Government officials at public rallies.
- B. Displaced and refugee children in Lebanon.
- C. International music festivals abroad.
- D. Wealthy patrons in private concerts.

15. What positive impact did Joy Fayad observe her performances having on the children?

- A. They are inspired to join the military.
- B. They are becoming more interested in political activism.
- C. They are changing the atmosphere, having fun, and getting used to music instead of bombs.
- D. They are learning to forget their past traumas completely.